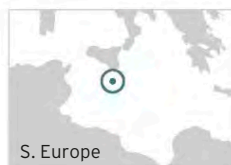


Megalithic Temples of Malta

More than 50 prehistoric temples believed to be the oldest free-standing structures in the world



From 6000–5000 BCE, the islands of Malta were settled by people of increasingly sophisticated culture who embarked on a thousand-year period of temple-building.

The Giants' Tower

The earliest two temples, known as *Ġgantija* (Giants' Tower), were built on the island of Gozo in about 3600 BCE. These temples were relatively simple in design, with a trilithon (a lintel supported by two uprights) entrance leading into semicircular chambers, or "apses," lined with large, upright stone slabs. Each apse contained a limestone altar, which finds of animal bones nearby suggest may have been used for sacrifices.

The megalithic temple-building period reached its peak between 3000 BCE and 2500 BCE, when temple complexes on the main island of Malta—such as those at Haġar Qim, Mnajdra, Skorba, and Tarxien—adopted the style of the *Ġgantija* temples, but often with a more complex ground plan of several apses.



While in the *Ġgantija* temples the two apses were approached through a small entrance chamber, in the larger temples there was a paved passageway (or in some cases a pair of passages) leading from the main entrance to the individual chambers. From the outside, the doorway into the temple from a leveled forecourt was marked by a stone archway, and the facade was made of a harder limestone than the interior.

Because of this, decoration in the form of animal and plant designs sculptured in relief was generally restricted to the insides of the temples.

◁ TEMPLE ART

The temples contain numerous carved artifacts, such as this sculpted figurine, showing a fine degree of craftsmanship.

▽ TEMPLE INTERIOR

The roofs of the interconnected chambers, or apses, within the temples were supported by carved pillars and entrance doorways in the form of trilithons.



△ SACRED SITE

In this aerial image, the remains of the circle of pillars and lintels can be clearly seen around the internal horseshoe-shaped arrangement of arches and central Altar Stone.

